

A Short Story: The ReboundBot [B1]

Sostituire il proprio ex con una versione migliorata: è l'idea rivoluzionaria di Lexi. Ma le cose non andranno come aveva immaginato.

Lexy watched as ten thousand new DomBots V27 came to life on the factory floor of XpertAI. They were facing ten thousand DomBots V26 and immediately began their first task — dismantling their predecessors, whose hardware and software would be recycled and reused. “Oh, the poor bots,” said Lexy’s grandmother, who was touring the factory before they went to lunch together. She was fascinated, if a little horrified, by Lexy’s role as XpertAI CEO. “Don’t you feel bad for them?” Lexy rolled her eyes. Her grandmother was a typical Gen Z-er. She viewed humanoid AI as more human than AI, convinced they’d eventually become self-aware and replace humanity. “No, Gran,” she said. “They’re machines, not sentient beings. Every new generation is programmed with the New and Improved Directive, to dispose of the AI it’s replacing in a sustainable way. At least we’re not dumping old tech in landfills, like in your day.” “I’d suppose that’s true,” conceded Gran. The world had changed since Gran was young, and now humanoid AIs, such as DomBots — programmed to do domestic tasks — were a part of everyday life. “You have to meet my creation,” said Lexy, when she and Gran returned to her office. She activated the generic-looking humanoid AI by her desk. Its face illuminated with a smile. “Oh, hello, Mrs. Walters,” it said, in an Irish accent. “And how is my favourite grand lady today?” “Remind you of anyone?” asked Lexy. Her grandmother looked surprised. “It’s... Ooooh, but it can’t be.” “But it is. Meet the New and Improved Brian.” Brian had been Lexy’s boyfriend for four years. She’d been devastated when they’d broken up. But then the break-up had inspired her to create the ReboundBot, an AI to help people rebound and recover from past relationships. She’d insisted on doing all the programming herself, ignoring objections from her subordinates. She was confident that, as the company’s CEO, she had the necessary programming skills, and besides, this was her personal project. She had programmed the ReboundBot as the New and Improved Brian, using all available material about her ex-boyfriend, from school records to professional bios to audio and video recordings. The ReboundBot had even

visited Brian at home, in the guise of a DeliveryBot, to perfect its imitation of him. "I'm going to test it out for a month before we release it to the world," she said. "Oh dear, I'm not sure that's such a good idea," said Gran. "What if you fall in love with him?" This was another crazy Gen Z idea, that AI would replace humans in relationships. Certainly, there was a niche market for RomBots, but most people wanted relationships with other humans, not machines. "It's not a 'him', it's an 'it'," she said. "And I'm not going to fall in love with it. I just want closure, that's all." Lexy's test of the ReboundBot, or the BrianBot, as she named it, was a complete success. The BrianBot had all the same characteristics as Brian, and all the same irritating habits. Those habits had been the cause of many arguments between them, and still were. However, the BrianBot was programmed to respond to Lexy's use of the code word 'Whatever' by conceding in any argument. "I've told you a million times not to put the empty milk carton back in the fridge," she said to the BrianBot one morning, initiating a common argument.

"What's the big deal?" the BrianBot responded. "Just order a new one." "I need it now, so I can have cereal for breakfast." "You can't have toast instead?" "No, I can't... Whatever!" At the mention of the code word, the BrianBot conceded. "You're right. It was inconsiderate of me. I'm so sorry." Of course, she and the BrianBot didn't argue all the time. Most of the time, the AI was kind and considerate, just as Brian had been, reminding her why she'd been with him for four years. "It helped me to see our relationship in a more balanced way," said Lexy, in her promotional video for the ReboundBot a few weeks later, "to appreciate the good times and accept the bad times, and eventually to find closure. And I know it can help you, too." The ReboundBot was an immediate success, selling ten thousand units in its first week. Before deactivating the BrianBot, Lexy took it to meet the real Brian. She thought he'd find it amusing, and besides, she wanted an opportunity to resolve things with him. She knocked on his door but got no response. "You looking for the Irish guy?" asked an elderly neighbour. "I haven't seen him in weeks. Perhaps he's gone back to Ireland." "Perhaps," said Lexy. "Or perhaps he's ignoring me," she said to the BrianBot as they left. "Who?" asked the BrianBot. "Brian." "But I am Brian." "Well, no, you're an AI." "But Brian was an AI." "No, Brian is human..." Lexy froze. "Why did you say 'was'?" "Was. Past tense. I am the New and Improved Brian." "Oh, my God. Oh, no. Oh,

God, no!" Lexy realised with horror the fatal flaw in her programming. AI was incapable of harming humans. But she had programmed the ReboundBot to perceive the human it was replacing as AI, which meant the BrianBot would have dismantled its predecessor when it visited him. She imagined the horror in Brian's apartment, and then the horror being inflicted by the ten thousand ReboundBots released into the world. It was every Gen Z fear realised, and it was all her fault.

Glossary

- **self-aware** = consapevoli di sé
- **dumping** = buttare
- **landfills** = discariche
- **grand** = splendida
- **argue** = discutere
- **Past tense** = tempo passato
- **flaw** = difetto
- **CEO** = amministratrice delegata (Chief Executive Officer)
- **rolled her eyes** = alzare gli occhi al cielo
- **Gran** = nonna
- **rebound** = riprendersi
- **confident** = sicura
- **in the guise of** = nei panni di
- **closure** = voltare pagina
- **harming** = fare male
- **sentient beings** = esseri senzienti
- **release** = lanciare
- **What's the big deal?** = qual è il problema?
- **besides** = inoltre
- **fault** = colpa
- **dispose** = disfarsi
- **Improved** = migliorare
- **Whatever** = vabbè, come vuoi
- **argument** = litigio
- **empty milk carton** = cartone del latte vuoto
- **amusing** = divertente
- **facing** = affrontare